

Research Methodology

Throughout this book, you've seen statistic after statistic and read story after story of everyday, run-of-the-mill millionaires across the United States. As we said at the start of the book, this was the largest, most comprehensive study of millionaires ever conducted. We spent seven months studying more than 10,000 millionaires to truly understand who they are, what they do, how they live, and how they achieved financial independence. And, as I've said, we focused specifically on net-worth millionaires, meaning people whose total net worth was at or above the \$1 million mark. That makes our research rather unique among other wealth studies. Most research on "the wealthy" focuses on high-income earners, but we think there's a big problem with that approach. Our decades of experience have shown us that "high income" does not automatically translate to "high net worth." To be blunt, there are far too many broke, financially stressed families in the country who are earning six figures. We didn't want to hear from them. We wanted to talk to millionaires—the true standard of financial independence.

For that reason, we targeted individuals with a net worth of \$1 million or more, regardless of their income. We worked with millionaires in all fifty states and in every major US city, conducting in-depth phone interviews and facilitating a series of detailed research questionnaires. We talked to millionaires in the suburbs, in rural areas, and in big cities. We talked to executives and farmers. We talked to people who were retired and those who were still working. We talked to people across a wide spectrum of professions, ethnicities, and socioeconomic backgrounds. We talked to as many millionaires as we could because, as the research shows, millionaires are everywhere. Then we took that research a step further and conducted